Bad Dog

By Steve Martin

"You're a bad dog, a very bad dog!" shouts Dr. Fogel.

I'll show you what a bad dog is, thinks Jasper, padding down the hallway to his dog bowl, where he can think.

INTRODUCTION

Dogs are descended from wild wolves, and a dog's perception of the world is based on his ancestral genes just like our perceptions are based upon our genes. For example, if you let your dog do as he pleases no matter how socially unacceptable his behavior, you perceive that you are showing your dog love and being good to him, but that is not what the dog perceives. The dog takes your lack of control of him as a sign that you are weak. He believes that he has attained alpha dog status in his pack and as the alpha dog, he IS the boss.

Then you wonder why he won't obey you. HA! He thinks that you should obey HIM because he is obviously in charge. Obedience training is not cruelty. Obedience training and teaching your dog how to behave himself

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Just remember that dogs perceive the world in a different way than you do, and it is up to you to see the world from the dog's point of view before you descend with a rolled up newspaper chanting "Bad Dog" by Steve Martin.

Sulking next to his dish, Jasper tries to sort everything out. The FedEx man is supposed to be barked at, dammit. When he is outside the gate, he is outside the threshold of recognition. As he nears, he comes inside the threshold of recognition. Of course I'm going to bark at him, even if I know who he is. The plumber is even lower than the FedEx man. I'm just saying, Watch out, he's got a wrench. Is that so terrible?

The cat slinks buy. Jasper thinks the one epithet he could never say: Fraidy.

In the next room, Dr. Fogel is on the phone. "Well, I need that package today, doggone it." Jasper shudders. I hate it when he uses that word. Does he know how it hurts me? Does he know what he's saying? Why can't he day Goddammit, like everyone else? Goddammit is a decent, benign swear word, no matter

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how you look at it. Even backward, it's . . . it's. . . oh my dog!

The doorbell rings. Jasper's up and running to the front door, barking. Master and dog arrive at the same time. "Quiet, Jasper! Quiet!" says Dr. Fogel, but Jasper can't keep quiet. The door opens. It's the FedEx man.

Oops, thinks Jasper. He immediately puts his nose between the deliveryman's legs. They love this; this will be my salvation, he calculates.

But from above he hears, "Bad dog! Bad, bad dog."

What? Bad dog? Jasper keeps on the happy face but is killed inside. He watches the exchange of signature and receipt then follows Him, hoping for a pat or a word of understanding or just anything. It does not come.

Jasper dips into his bowl of water, hiding his big sad eyes. This is a major, major problem, he thinks. That night, lying on his sawdust-filled bed, Jasper realizes that there's something in his brain telling him to

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distinguish between the Federal Express man, who must be barked at in all circumstances, and Granny Fogel, for whom he demonstrates his admiration by rolling over and showing his genitals. But how can I stop myself from doing what I want to do – nay, what I must do? This urge is so strong, based on so many factors, so many subtle discernments. He decides that he lacks some key piece of information, some general rule of understanding that would put him on the clear path. He resolves to search for that knowledge by taking a trip around the world. For Jasper, the world is defined by a five-foot fence that surrounds his yard, the house, and all its contents.

The next morning, Jasper is out early. He sidles along the fence, hugging the wall, nose lowered into the grass. After an hour, he realizes that what he's doing is pointless, except for the pure fun of it all. He hangs around the kitchen for a while, doing the big-eyes thing, but get nothing. Unrewarded, he moves to his bed for a snooze. Jasper puts his nose next to his last saved biscuit and nuzzles it. He thinks, Questing is hard, and

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he rolls over on his back, sticks his legs in the air, and falls asleep.

Falling hard into a dream, Jasper imagines himself paddling through the air in a vast gallery of paintings. Although he's never actually been to a museum, he once guided himself accidentally through London's Tate Gallery Internet site (the letters T-A-T-E are all left-handers on a keyboard, and one lucky paw slap sent Jasper spiraling into cyberspace). Now, in his dream, he is able to whirl and twist in the air, viewing the pictures up close and reading their museum labels. His dream, swirling up from his simple unconscious, changes each painter's bio: "Johann Fuseli, Swiss painter and former dog." "Giovanni Battista Tiepolo, Italian painter and former dog." Jasper sees that these artists have transformed the canine within themselves into wonderful works of art.

The doorbell jars Jasper out of his sleep. Consciousness takes over, and the beautiful dream fades back into his thin cortex. Rising, he looks through a series of windows, from the bedroom to the kitchen, and

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beyond the kitchen to the street. He sees the white rectangle of the FedEx truck. Impulsively, he runs toward the front door.

Charging down the hall, he can feel the bark welling up inside him. He is like a boxer with a coiled left hook about to be thrown, like the clapper of an alarm, already in motion toward its bell. He knows what he is facing: the cold censure of his master, balanced by the deliciously frightened face of the FedEx man. The bark churns deep within him. He feels it in his belly, moving up through his lungs. His body chemistry pumps him forward like a jockey's whip, and he turns the corner to the foyer. There in gleaming white is the target, handing over the trim FedEx box to Jasper's beloved and vulnerable master. As he slows, the fleshy part of his paws struggling against the hardwood floor, Jasper's locomotion compresses his energy, forcing the bark into his throat. With his master looking on, he opens his mouth; the bark now lies just behind his tongue. As it rolls over the damp, spongy, pink surface, the miracle that is Art rises from his shallow unconscious and

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transforms the sound waves, curving the pointy spikes of the highs and rounding the crevices of the jagged lows. Jasper looks up at his master, and out comes, in a lovely baritone:

We're having a heat wave

A tropical heat wave . . .

Now there is not a sound. A performer's eon passes: the time between the final note of the aria and the whooshing, enveloping applause of the audience. Finally, into the silent ethereal mist that swarms in Jasper's head, comes his master's voice: "Good boy – you're a good, good boy."

Jasper turns, feeling the euphoric relief of an adrenaline shutdown. He moves away from the door. The cat walks by. There but for grace of God go I, thinks Jasper. He walks into the kitchen, laps some water, looks back at the startled tableau by the front door, and goes outside to lie in the sun.

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AWARD HISTORY

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